<challenge> Humanitarian risk

Ground Truth: a trusted expert loop for humanitarian risk analysis

How can ACAPS turn the scattered knowledge of humanitarian experts into sharper, better grounded risk analysis, without costing those experts their time or their anonymity?

Project	**Hackathon for Good #8**	Theme	**Humanitarian risk**
Challenge owner	**Lars Peters**	Organisation	**ACAPS**
On site	**Anssi Anonen, ACAPS**	Contact	**info@hackathonforgood.org**
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Background

ACAPS is an independent humanitarian analysis organisation that monitors more than 100 crises around the world every day. From that monitoring, its analysts build the ACAPS Risk List: an overview of risks that could trigger a new crisis or a sharp deterioration in humanitarian needs. Each risk is rated on the probability that it materialises and on its expected humanitarian impact, both on a five-point scale, which together give a low, medium or high risk level. UN agencies, NGOs and donors use these analyses to prepare and act before a situation escalates.

Today, that analysis draws on public sources and on conversations with a small number of experts. ACAPS then publishes. What happens after publication, and whether the people closest to a crisis actually recognise the picture, stays largely invisible.

This is the context ACAPS offers you as a team during Hackathon for Good #8.

Problem statement

Humanitarian crises move fast and rarely come into focus. Decision-makers often lack actionable data on what is unfolding across different theatres, and there is no shared situational awareness of how crises are developing.

ACAPS wants to close the gap between its analysis and what experts see on the ground, but today:

- Analysts and practitioners often sense a risk long before it shows up in a report, but that knowledge travels through informal conversations with peers and then disappears.
- There is no structured way to ask a broader, trusted group of experts: do you recognise this analysis, what are we missing, and how likely is it to happen?
- ACAPS cannot learn, over time, whose judgement proves most reliable.
- Experts are busy and some work in sensitive contexts. They will not engage with yet another platform that eats their time or exposes them.
- Expert communities are hard to keep alive: comparable expert forecasting pools have seen participation drop off after launch.

Within this broad problem, the challenge focuses on the experts who contribute to ACAPS analysis, not on the readers of its reports.

The challenge

How can we help a trusted network of humanitarian experts to **challenge, enrich and forecast** ACAPS risk analyses, through a moderated expert loop in which **each contributor controls their own anonymity**, when a crisis starts to shift or a new risk analysis is published, instead of relying on one-off conversations with a single expert and informal chats among peers?

An example of a question the solution should be able to handle: "What are the three biggest risks in Chad that might worsen humanitarian outcomes in the next six months?"

Two directions

Teams can work in one direction or combine both. The strongest solutions show how both feed one loop back into ACAPS analysis, with outcomes shared publicly.

1. Ground truthing

Experts react to ACAPS risk analyses and the triggers for deterioration that ACAPS analysts have identified: do they agree, how do they expect the situation to evolve, what is missing, what is completely different? Think of a Delphi-style process: experts respond independently, see an anonymised summary of the group, and can refine their view in the next round.

2. Forecasting

Experts estimate how likely specific events are within a six-month horizon. Because these questions resolve over time, the tool can build a track record and gradually surface the most accurate "super estimators". The Risk Radar export contains the real outcomes of earlier risks, so you can test your scoring approach before any expert joins.

Guiding questions

Use these as a compass, not a checklist:

- How can an expert contribute something valuable in a few minutes, at the moment it matters?
- How does each expert choose and change their level of anonymity, and how do you guarantee that nothing is attributed publicly?
- How do you aggregate and feed back the group's view without creating groupthink?
- How do you turn ACAPS risks into forecast questions that can actually be resolved and scored after six months?
- How does ACAPS moderate the group and use the outcomes without adding a heavy workload?

Who you are helping: the expert

You are building for ACAPS, but you are designing for the experts who feed its analysis.

The expert panel

For each country or context, ACAPS expects a panel of around 5 to 10 experts, to keep it manageable. Typical profiles:

- conflict experts, often active on social media;
- anticipatory action and early warning practitioners;

- researchers;
- local NGO leaders;
- anyone else with a strong interest in anticipatory analysis.

Most will have a humanitarian background, but that is not a requirement. What makes the difference is deep knowledge of their own context, and a view on how the humanitarian situation is likely to evolve depending on the triggers for deterioration identified by ACAPS analysts.

The four personas below come from ACAPS' own research, based on 30 interviews with users of its products. They help you understand the wider ACAPS audience: the first three are closest to the experts who would contribute; the fourth reads the published outcomes.

01

Jose
Head of UN agency, regional office

Covers six countries from a regional office in Jordan and acts as a filter between headquarters and his field teams. Figures he receives sometimes differ from what his colleagues see, which sparks useful discussions.

Struggles with:
Information about his countries is not always well reflected on humanitarian platforms. He wants an easy way for field users to give quality feedback to headquarters.

"You never know how a regional crisis can further spread out."

02

Emily
Head of methodology, donor agency HQ

Collects data in emergencies worldwide, mainly on nutrition and health, and validates what she reads with partners who collect raw data.

Struggles with:
Judging which sources are reliable. When something in an analysis does not sound right, she has to go elsewhere to check it.

"Determining reliability in the information going into the analysis can be tricky."

03

Pierre
MEAL officer, IFRC, field

Deployed for months at a time as one of the first people in a new crisis, currently on the regional food crisis from Nairobi.

Struggles with:
Scenario planning is increasingly demanded, but he lacks the method and time to do it well, and doubts the value of the effort.

"I am very interested in getting the right skillset to undertake it properly."

04

Aisha
Country director, INGO, field

Leads a team of over 150 people in one country, but follows other crises to adapt her fundraising strategy. Relies on ACAPS for credible context.

Struggles with:
No one tells her how coming political events will affect her programmes. She wants better anticipation of what is next.

"More information on political projections would help me."

Sustainable development goals

SDG 1 No Poverty, SDG 2 Zero Hunger, SDG 3 Good Health and Well-being, SDG 10 Reduced Inequalities, SDG 16 Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions, SDG 17 Partnerships for the Goals.

Criteria

Beneficial if feasible.

- **Must:** be easy to use and feel like an interesting community and experience that experts want to come back to. Each expert chooses their own level of anonymity (for example: known to ACAPS, pseudonymous to peers, or fully anonymous), and individual contributions are always anonymous to the public.
- **Should:** maintain deep engagement over time while respecting the experts' time, with short, focused contributions rather than long sessions. Fit a known, trusted group moderated by ACAPS and deliberately kept small: around 5 to 10 experts per country or context.
- **Should not:** focus solely on time spent in the app. This is about the quality of the information, not engagement metrics. It should not feel like an AI chatbot.
- **Could:** build a scoreboard of "super estimators" that recognises consistently accurate experts over time, show where experts agree and disagree, including by geography, work on mobile and low bandwidth, and support French and other working languages of field experts.
- **Can have:** AI support behind the scenes that helps ACAPS moderators synthesise expert input, as long as the experience for experts stays human.

Data

ACAPS shares an export of its internal Risk Radar for this challenge. All data, documentation and supporting material are available in the challenge GitHub repository.

Do not use personal data of real experts during the hackathon: work with synthetic users and example contributions.

Available data

1. ACAPS Risk Radar export (via the repository)

Per risk, the export contains:

- **What the risk is:** title, type (new emerging risk, deterioration of an existing crisis, or future impact of a hazard), country, subnational areas, category and triggers.
- **How ACAPS rated it:** probability (very low to very high), impact (1 to 5), overall risk level, expected exposure, expected impact and priority needs, with the rationale behind each rating.
- **How it changed:** dated histories of probability, impact, risk level, trend and rationale.
- **What actually happened:** status (active, materialised or not materialised), what materialised (hazard, impact or both), a description with sources, and the date it materialised.

2. ACAPS Risk List (public, optional)

The published risk list, released monthly, via the ACAPS API (free account, token authentication) or the Humanitarian Data Exchange. Useful if you want to show how your solution would run on live data.

Why this data matters

Because the export records what actually happened to earlier risks, you can test ideas against real outcomes. For example, among published risks that have since been resolved, roughly eight in ten of those ACAPS rated "High" materialised, against about four in ten of those rated "Low". Use this to simulate expert estimates, build and test a scoring method for your scoreboard, or show experts how past analyses played out.

A live example to build your demo around: risk R1043, *"Escalating cross-border insecurity linked to the Sudan conflict increases protection risks and humanitarian needs in eastern Chad"*, currently active and rated high.

What you deliver

At the end of the hackathon, each team delivers on Junction:

- A working prototype or demo.
- A 3-minute pitch for the jury.
- A repository link and a short description: what you built, how it works, and why.

Follow-up opportunity

ACAPS wants to build a living, trusted expert community that makes its risk analysis sharper, faster and better grounded in what is happening on the ground. The two to three most promising solutions will be tested in a pilot with a small ACAPS expert group, and ACAPS is happy to host a presentation where teams discuss their solution with the ACAPS team.

The analyst material is already in place, so the pilot can start right after the hackathon or in early December, and run for around two months. A critical part of the pilot will be finding experts who commit to taking part, so solutions that make joining and staying involved easy have a clear head start.

Resources and inspiration

- **ACAPS on site.** Alexander Harper (Alex), based in The Hague, will be at the hackathon to answer questions and give feedback.
- **Challenge repository.** Data, documentation and supporting material: github.com/Hackathon-for-Good-The-Hague/HFG8-ACAPS-Ground-Truth
- **Risk methodology explainer.** A short explainer from ACAPS on how risks are identified, rated and followed up.
- ACAPS: Introduction to ACAPS Risk Analysis Methodology (May 2019)
- ACAPS: Risk List and Global Risk Analysis
- Early Warning Project (US Holocaust Memorial Museum): crowd forecasting with an expert opinion pool
- CASRAI: the Delphi method, building expert consensus in rounds
- Good Judgment: the superforecasters' track record

Disclaimer

This brief is a starting point, not a specification. Teams are free to reinterpret the problem within the criteria above. ACAPS data is used under ACAPS' terms of use.

Challenge owners: Lars Peters and Alexander Harper, ACAPS | Questions about the hackathon: info@hackathonforgood.org